



Bachelor Project Applied Computer Science
(Academic year 2025—2026)

Federated Learning

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1 Scope & Vision (6, 570)

1.1 Background

The project was carried out in company Result d.o.o. They are a software development company, but also focus on data, artificial intelligence, and business solutions. They work on many projects, some of which are european. One such is eEarly — an open platform for analysation and gathering of health data[1]. It was also the umbrella for this bachelor work.

European Union has many regulations and laws when it comes to data, and there are even more for each individual country, organisation,... This introduces challenges for projects like eEarly that utilize artificial intelligence and deal with sensitive medical data. From here we can easily see the motivation for my bachelor project: To find the bridge between sensitive data, artificial intelligence, and a lake of regulations.

1.2 Problem statement

In an ideal situation, an artificial intelligence model could train on all data without restrictions. In reality, besides strict European Union laws, each hospital keeps its data isolated. This reveals the main issue: An artificial intelligence model can only train on one hospital. Consequences of this are bad model performance, predictions, and ultimately uselessness of the new technology. From this follows the proposal, which is not to loosen the law, but to explore techniques like federated learning[2] to satisfy both the regulations and the artificial intelligence's need for data.

1.3 Intention

The main intention of the project is to develop a federated learning proof of concept for the company, which can be later on used as a starting point for other projects and might be fully implemented, possibly in a healthcare environment, or be a new privacy-oriented artificial intelligence solution that the company could sell.

1.4 Scope within the bachelor project (MVP – need to have)

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1.5 Ultimate scope (want to have)

What is the ultimate scope?

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2 Software Requirements Specification (8, 760)

2.1 Target group

Who are the target groups of the tool to be developed?

What aspects must you consider for these target groups?

What are the needs of these target groups?

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2.2 Method

In order to discover, track, and prioritize all requirements, I was asking a variety of questions — especially in the beginning — and kept sorting them by importance using the MoSCoW frame-work[3]. Besides being very simple and clear, this method has proven itself in my previous projects, which is the main reason why I chose it as my main tool at this stage. All of this was done on Jira in a kanban board, so that it has always remained organized and visible to me and mentors.

2.3 Requirements

What are the functional requirements?

Which features/user stories did you design?

What are the non-functional requirements?

Which features/user stories belong to the MVP?

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3 Preliminary Research (12, 1140)

3.1 Federated Learning

Imagine there are researchers working on a project and they do not tell each other anything about themselves, their names, education, age. . . They only contribute with their current knowledge without revealing their personal information. This is what federated learning tries to achieve [4]. Later on I talk about global and local models, in this example, researchers play a role of local models, and the project would be a global model.

Federated learning is a *decentralized learning* technique, which means the learning is not accomplished centrally on a single device — normally a server — but is kept on the edge, close to the main source of the data. Since it is decentralized, this also leads to great benefits regarding *privacy* and regulations as data is not moved out of its safe zone. In practice, we accomplish this using two types artificial intelligence models: global and local. The algorithm [5] contains the following steps:

1. Global model is initialized.
2. Global model sends a copy of himself to all the local models. In a medical example, local models would be hospitals.
3. Local models train on sensitive (medical) data. There is no data exchanged between *any* of the models.
4. Local models send the weights to the global model. One can image they share their knowledge, without data.
5. Global model combines the weights — usually by averaging them —, and becomes better at predicting diseases, for example.
6. The process repeats from the second step. Each local model now becomes better as it receives the average “knowledge” from all others.

3.2 Related projects

Numerous similar projects with alike problems can be found, though there are some more noticeable and important.

In 2017, Google introduced federated learning while implementing the “Next word suggestion” feature on their Gboard. They took user interaction as their input and trained an artificial model to predict users next word. Without this innovating project, all the private typing data from millions of devices would have to be transferred to a central server. At this point, we can easily understand Google’s main concerns of standard data pipeline: Bandwidth usage and latency. [4], [6]

During COVID-19 pandemic, researchers all over the world have established connections and collaborated to create an artificial intelligence platform that predicts whether you have the disease based on CT (X-ray) chest scans. This was an initiative called Unified CT-COVID AI Diagnostic Initiative (UCADI), and the reason I am mentioning it here is that they have made it all possible by using federated learning. [6], [7]

3.3 Related solutions

Main characteristics of federative learning described in section 3.1 are decentralized learning and privacy; I use this two for finding related solutions below.

3.3.1 Decentralized Learning

Fog computing is an improved approach on top of federated learning. It originates from the network challenges of federated learning, focuses on layered architecture of communication between local and global model, and aims to reduce network traffic. [8]

Being a decentralized technique, federated learning still has a central, global model that aggregates all parameter updates. *Gossip learning* — also called distributed federated learning (DFL) [9] — is even simpler in this sense, as it does not have a global model. The updates and aggregations are all taken care by the local models themselves. [10]

Similar to gossip learning is *swarm learning*. The main difference is its use of blockchain peer-to-peer communication that is configured between the local models. This enables swarm learning to be a very related solution, with even better potential privacy and fault tolerance (because there is no single point of failure like the global model server). [9]

From the three main decentralized learning alternatives, swarm learning would be the most advanced and related proof of concept to be developed, and definitely long away from the MVP. Fog computing is too extensive and our aim is more to increase privacy than to reduce network traffic.

3.3.2 Privacy

In general, *homomorphic encryption* creates a possibility to make operations on encrypted data, without ever decrypting it. This can be applied both to normal and federated machine learning, although it is rather an add-on than a replacement for the latter. The challenges include computational overhead and lack of support for some operations, thus finding a balance between privacy and performance is an important question. [11], [12]

Secure multiparty computation allows to split private data from many participants, share it in this split form, and let any participant compute (public) functions, such as average and maximum without knowing any other participants' private data [13]. In federated learning, sharing weights with the central server still brings up some privacy concerns that can be handled by applying secure multiparty computation [14]. This adds some computation cost, along with even more communication overhead. [11]

Differential privacy introduces random noise to private data while still maintaining its statistical properties [15]. This means that individual values like age are uninterpretable for any middleman between global and local models, thus guarding the system from inference and poisoning attacks. For example, inference attack would mean that a middleman can infer whether a person has a certain disease from the outputs of the global model [16]; data poisoning attack would mean that a middleman intercepts and modifies the weights sent to the global or local model, making the predictions of the model less accurate or corrupted. [17]

All privacy alternatives mentioned above are strongly related, but optional for the scope of this work. They clearly point out main weak parts of the federated learning which have to be kept in mind in phases later on.

3.4 Required technology

What technology is required to develop the solution or your digital product?

Which programming languages did you use?

Which programming languages did you test but ultimately not use in the final development?

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3.5 Comparative study

From [18]–[20], I have extracted four main open-source frameworks suitable for the project. One of them, namely FedML, had vastly different opinions among papers, so I did not take this framework into consideration.

Flower: It's main characteristic is easy integration with different deep learning frameworks, and that it offers a beginner- and prototype-friendly entrance into federated learning [19], [21]–[23]. As Flower was new in 2025, research papers from that year showed it has lacked community support and documentation [19], [21], which has changed the next year, and is now apparently considered to have strong documentation [22]. It is especially well-suited for edge IoT devices and production ready [21], although additional privacy features have to be engineered manually [22], unlike with frameworks like NVIDIA FLARE.

NVIDIA Federated Learning Application Runtime Environment (NVIDIA FLARE): It's main characteristic is enterprise-readiness [21]–[24], with many built-in features, especially for privacy [24]. It is overall very good in all aspects (also documentation) [18], [21], which is the reason it might seem heavy for smaller projects [22]. The main disadvantages is that you are restricted to the NVIDIA ecosystem [21].

TensorFlow Federated (TFF): It's main characteristic is that is most widely used, but complex, only compatible with TensorFlow, and can be integrated into the least environments. [19], [21]

The choice comes down to Flower or NVIDIA FLARE. Luckily, these two have recently announced collaboration and compatibility between each other [25]–[27], meaning Flower can be integrated into the NVIDIA runtime environment and immediately leveraging enterprise-ready environment from NVIDIA and simplicity from Flower. For this reason, Flower will be used to create the prototype.

3.6 Final selected technology / project tools

Which project tools did you use?

Which development methodologies did you apply?

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3.7 Choice reflection

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4 Reflection (16, 1520)

4.1 General Reflection

4.1.1 Achieved objectives

Were the project objectives achieved?

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4.1.2 Test framework / technique

Which test framework or technique was chosen and why?

Which parts of the project were or were not tested, and why?

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4.1.3 Security

Was security considered in the project and how was it addressed?

Where do you see possible improvements in the project's security?

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4.1.4 Improvements

Where do you see improvements in general?

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4.1.5 Added value of the project

What do you consider the greatest added value of the project?

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4.1.6 Future opportunities

What are the next steps or future opportunities for the project?

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4.1.7 Next steps

What are the next steps or future opportunities for the project?

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4.2 Personal Reflection

If you were to do the project again, what would you approach differently?

What impact do you think the research or developed tool has on people (ethics/inclusion)?

What impact do you think the research or developed tool has on society (economy/policy/education)?

What impact do you think the research or developed tool has on the climate (energy/sustainability)?

What will stay with you most about the project?

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4.3 Feedback

What did you think overall about the integrated bachelor project and the distribution with the traineeship?

Do you have suggestions for improvement for the integrated bachelor project?

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5 Appendices

Meeting minutes van vergaderingen

The backlog

The story mapping (with different releases)

Example mappings (if available or in another format)

Gherkin scenarios (if available)

Login credentials

Installation manual

User manual

5.1 Meeting minutes

TODO QA David: What is this?

5.2 Backlog

5.3 Story mapping

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